workers. Economic booms and busts affected employment opportunities, especially in the agricultural slump of the early 1840s and the economic depression in the early 1890s. The highly seasonal nature of the Australian colonial workforce had important implications for working life, such as uneven earnings across one year for many workers. Moreover, there were always Australians who were out of luck and dependent on charity. Poor sanitary conditions in late 19th-century slums in Sydney and Melbourne also affected the image of Australia as a destination for the working class.